

Discovering the Megacity

The American Dream, Urban Life, and the Search
for Authenticity in Coming to America



An aerial view of the New York City skyline at sunset. The sky is a mix of orange, pink, and purple. The Empire State Building is prominent on the left, and other skyscrapers are visible in the background. The city lights are beginning to glow.

What Does the External World Have to Offer?

For generations, megacities like New York have stood as beacons for immigrants and dreamers seeking to reinvent themselves. This presentation explores the tropes of urban American life through the comedic lens of Prince Akeem—a man who gave up a kingdom to find an authentic life in the concrete canyons of 1980s America.



The Golden Cage of Zamunda



Absolute Pampering

Waking to a chorus of attendants, bathed by servants, walkways paved with rose petals.



Complete Dependency

A 21-year-old man who has never been allowed to tie his own shoes.



Arranged Obedience

A future bride trained from birth to bark like a dog on command and have no independent thoughts.

Core Insight: Akeem possesses extreme material wealth but entirely lacks personal independence. He seeks a partner who will arouse his intellect, not just obey his orders.

Bypassing the Palace for the Pavement

The Waldorf-Astoria /
The Palace

Queens

Upon landing in New York, Akeem's aide Semmi expects to stay in a luxury Manhattan hotel fitting their royal status. Akeem deliberately rejects this, demanding to be taken to Queens.

He specifically requests "the most common part" and the "poorest room" to experience the unvarnished, authentic reality of the American city from the ground up.

The Culture Shock of Authenticity

Zamunda (Expectation)	New York / Queens (Reality)
Walkways dusted with fresh rose petals.	Sidewalks covered in broken glass and chalk outlines.
Accommodations: Palatial estates with private bathing attendants.	A single shared bathroom for the floor, and a room where the previous tenant's dog was eaten by rats.
Possessions: Opulent royal robes and endless wealth.	Possessions: Luggage instantly stolen upon arrival on the sidewalk.

Synthesis Takeaway: Akeem joyfully embraces the squalor, theft, and insults. To him, the hardship is the price of admission to a real life.

The Barbershop as a Cultural Hub

The neighborhood barbershop serves as a chaotic democratic forum. Akeem silently observes passionate, overlapping debates about American sports legends (Joe Louis vs. Rocky Marciano) and racial identity.

Joe Louis! Rocky Marciano was the great

A man has the right to change his name to whatever he wants... It's a free country!

Racial identity is about...!

That's what I'm saying!

Cultural Lesson: This scene introduces Akeem to the vibrant, argumentative, and proudly free-spirited nature of working-class urban Americans, where respect is fiercely debated, not inherited.

The Diversity of Urban Nightlife



The Devil Worshipper



The Aspiring Pop-Star/
Actress / Director



The Aggressive
Opportunist

Akeem and Semmi navigate the chaotic local bar scene, encountering radically bizarre personalities. In a megacity of millions, finding a true intellectual and emotional match proves to be like finding a needle in a haystack.



Finding the Right Environment

Advised by the barber that “decent women don’t hang out in bars,” Akeem attends a local community rally.

Key Elements of the Hub:

- The civic leader (Reverend Brown) stirring the crowd.
- The earnest, untalented local act (Randy Watson and Sexual Chocolate).
- The community fundraising effort.

The Turning Point:

Here, Akeem spots Lisa McDowell—independent, fiercely civic-minded, and authentic. She is the antithesis of his arranged bride.

The McDowell's Hustle

Cleo McDowell embodies the aggressive, scrappy urban entrepreneur. He defends his local fast-food business against corporate giants through sheer denial and slight alterations.

His: The Golden Arcs	Theirs: The Golden Arches
 The Golden Arcs	 The Golden Arches

His:
Golden Arcs, the
Big Mick, plain
buns.

Theirs:
Golden Arches, the
Big Mac, sesame
seed buns.

Cultural Insight: McDowell represents the intense drive to build generational wealth from nothing, rising from a cramped nine-person shack to a suburban home in Jamaica Estates.

The American Work Ethic

“He who would learn to fly one day must first learn to stand and walk.” — Nietzsche (quoted by Akeem while mopping)



Assistant Manager
(The ultimate local dream)



Working the Grill



Washing Lettuce



Garbage Disposal
& Mopping Floors

Synthesis: Akeem cheerfully accepts manual labor. This satirizes, yet deeply honors, the classic immigrant narrative: shedding past titles to earn one's place through hard, honest sweat.

Wealth vs. Worth



Akeem (The Worker)

Represents inherent nobility and dignity. Stripped of his royal bank account, he must rely on his character, manners, and work ethic to win Lisa's respect.



Darryl (The Heir)

Represents flashy, inherited wealth. He relies on his family's hair product fortune to secure Lisa, treating her as a trophy who won't need to work.

The Conflict: Cleo McDowell heavily favors Darryl purely for his capital, dismissing Akeem as a peasant—unaware of the profound irony of the situation.

Earning Respect in the Concrete Jungle



The Royal Urbanite:

“Please do not use obscene language in front of our customers.”

Impact:

He earns the true, unbought respect of his boss and peers. Action dictates status.

When an armed robber holds up McDowell's, Akeem's royal guards are absent. He must rely entirely on his own courage and martial arts training, using a humble wooden mop handle to disarm the thief.

The Past Catches Up

King Jaffe Joffer arrives in Queens with his full royal entourage, treating the gritty apartment building like a subjugated territory and attempting to pay off Cleo McDowell with millions of dollars to leave Akeem alone.

The American Pushback:

Despite his earlier obsession with wealth, Cleo McDowell violently rejects the King's insult to his daughter, shouting:

"This is America, Jack. I don't care who you are!"

Renouncing the Throne for Love



Confronted by Lisa's feeling of betrayal over his hidden identity, Akeem proves his intentions in the ultimate way. Standing in the middle of a gritty Queens street, he loudly declares his willingness to renounce his crown entirely.

Synthesis: He proves that the person is infinitely more valuable than the position. True wealth is building a life based on mutual respect and individual merit, stripping away the titles of the Old World.

A Tale of Two Worlds

Coming to America uses the chaotic, vibrant backdrop of a megacity to prove that authenticity cannot be inherited or arranged—it must be discovered through friction.

Takeaway:

The majestic promise of the New York skyline is – ultimately fulfilled not in the penthouses of Manhattan, but in the gritty, hard-working, independent communities of Queens. The city provided the ultimate canvas for a Prince to finally become a Man.

